was a product of another era and very different international circumstances. India's recent realignments are instead about positioning itself as a stronger and more capable actor in a more contested and interdependent world.

This book is meant as a basic introduction to India and the world, one that remedies some of the shortcomings of the existing literature. It is intended to encompass some big ideas and themes in a concise and serviceable manner. The title—which might be loosely translated from the classical Sanskrit as 'a treatise on the world'—hopefully connotes the necessary degree of ambition, scope, and timelessness. For it to be India's world, a Vishwa Shastra is necessary.

The Arguments

This book, particularly Part I: 'History', is meant to be more descriptive than polemical. Readers are invited to draw their own conclusions about events and developments. But the more discerning might notice a few underlying but consistent themes. In the spirit of self-awareness, these are worth highlighting explicitly at the outset.

The first is that India has long had a national strategy. Indeed, it has a rich strategic culture and tradition of statecraft. In some sense, this should not be surprising. However, the belief that India lacks either a strategic culture or the capacity for strategic thought remains an unfortunately prevalent notion in many quarters, including in India. To be sure, strategies often change and adjust, even when fundamental interests do not. The narrative arc therefore underscores changing international circumstances and New Delhi's shifting responses. The opportunities and challenges confronting India in 2024 look very different from those in, say, 1994, 1974, or 1954, and it would be foolish to expect India to think and act in exactly the same way.

Second, this strategy has for the most part had decidedly realist underpinnings. Ultimately, India, like all sovereign states, has had to look out for its own interests. Contested outcomes were often shaped by the balance of power. Mutually beneficial economic exchanges, effective